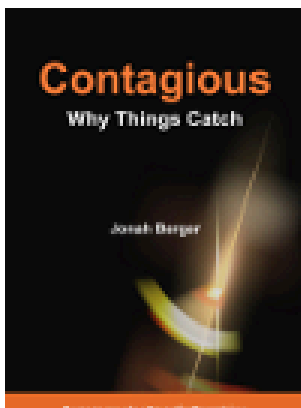




CONTAGIOUS

Why Things Catch On

JONAH BERGER



The Big "So What"

Why do some products and ideas spread like wildfire while others fail to catch on? In this book, Wharton marketing professor Jonah Berger shares **the 6 STEPPS or ingredients for creating viral content that are more likely to spread via word-of-mouth (WOM)**. These insights are relevant for anyone who wants to build awareness, spread ideas or grow a customer base more effectively.



Introduction



Most people believe that products and ideas become successful due to 3 factors: quality, price, and advertising. Although these factors are relevant, they don't tell the full story, e.g. a free, low-quality YouTube video can still go viral with no advertising. Social influences and word-of-mouth (WOM) drive 20-50% of all purchasing decisions. These include product reviews, recommendations by friends/colleagues, and so on. WOM is more effective than traditional advertising because:

- It's more persuasive since we tend to share both the pros and cons of a product or service candidly, making our recommendations more objective and believable.
- It's also more targeted since we only share information and stories with people whom we think would be interested in them.

The question is, how can you create content that's more likely to get passed on via WOM?

KEY QUOTES

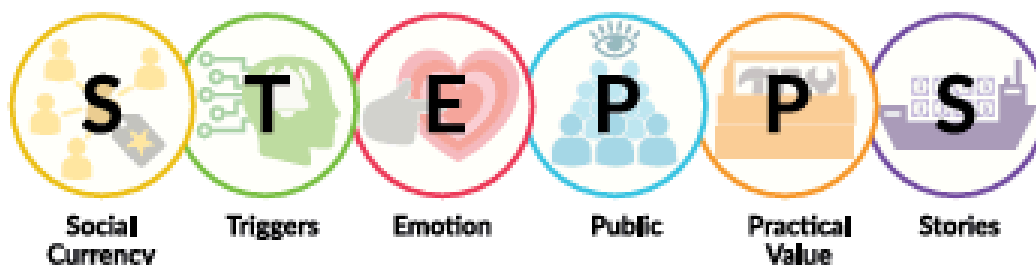
"While traditional advertising is still useful, word of mouth from everyday Joes and Janes is at least ten times more effective."

 Berger holds a Ph.D. in marketing and spent 10 years studying various types of content—ranging from products to articles, political messages and baby names—to uncover what spread and what didn't. He collected and analyzed data from many sources (e.g. marketing agencies and news websites), and ran experiments to test different content. In this book, he shares how he proved/disproved various factors/hypotheses to arrive at the 6 ingredients (STEPPS) behind social contagion. **By applying these 6 principles, you can make any content more contagious**, i.e. to spread from person to person via WOM.

- In *The Tipping Point*, Malcolm Gladwell suggests that to create virality, you need the right people to spread the message. However, Berger's research shows that contagious content is so viral in itself that it can spread regardless of who is talking about it. It's like how a good joke will still be funny even if it's told by an average person.
- People also tend to over-estimate the level of online virality. A study by the Keller Fay Group found that only 7% of WOM happens online; most social influence actually happens offline over daily activities like a dinner conversation. Reaching masses of people online isn't as important as ensuring the content is viral in the first place.



The 6 STEPPS to Creating Contagious Content



Principle #1: Social Currency

 Our social image is affected by many factors, including the job/title we hold, the clothes we wear, the house/cars we own and the things we say. **Social Currency refers to things that help people to look good and improve their social influence.**

KEY QUOTES

"Follow these six key STEPPS, or even just a few of them, and you can harness social influence and word of mouth to get any product or idea to catch on."

"Contagious content is...so inherently viral that it spreads regardless of who is doing the talking."

"Just as people use money to buy products or services, they use social currency to achieve desired positive impressions among their families, friends, and colleagues."

- People want to appear smart, hip, rich, and cool (instead of seeming stupid, boring, poor or geeky). **We share things that make us look good.** There are 3 ways to generate Social Currency: (i) make your product/idea remarkable, (ii) leverage game mechanics, and (iii) make it scarce/exclusive.



Make your product/idea remarkable. People love to talk about things that are unusual, surprising, extraordinary, or worthy of mention. That's because talking about remarkable things makes *us* appear remarkable too.

- Identify your inner remarkability or what makes your product/idea truly stand out. Remarkability could come from breaking an expected pattern, doing something seemingly-impossible, or generating mystery/controversy.
- For example, Blendtec went viral with a series of "Will it Blend?" videos on Youtube—the videos showed its blenders reducing tough items (e.g. golf balls, iPhones) to dust. The Blair Witch Project (which was filmed on a handheld camera for \$35,000) grossed more than \$248 million worldwide because it got people debating if the movie was based on a true story.



Leverage game mechanics to make people feel good about their achievements. When people "win" a game, trophy, or award, they want to brag about their accomplishments. In the process, they also share about your brand or message.

- Create Social Currency in 2 ways: (i) *use metrics or status symbols* (e.g. point systems, leaderboards, badges, trophies) to make accomplishments visible, and (ii) help people to *publish* their achievements. For example, airlines have successfully gamified air travel with their frequent flier programs. Passengers fly with certain airlines to collect air miles and move up the rewards hierarchy, then brag about their achievements (e.g. when they achieve Diamond status).
- You can also run contests based on popular votes. As participants rally others to vote for them, they also create awareness for your brand or campaign. Burberry's sales increased by 50% when it ran a campaign featuring pictures of people wearing their trenchcoats—people whose photos were featured ended up sharing about it and driving others to Burberry's website.

KEY QUOTES

"To get people talking we need to craft messages that help them achieve these desired impressions."

"Game mechanics help generate social currency because doing well makes us look good."



Use scarcity and exclusivity to make people feel like insiders. People assume that if something is hard to obtain, it must be special or desirable. Access to scarce or exclusive items/news makes people feel like insiders, and they'd want to brag about their special status.

- Scarcity is about limiting something's availability. You can do that by (i) limiting the number of units produced/released, (ii) restricting the time/place to buy, or (iii) creating the impression that it will sell out quickly. For example, McDonald's McRib didn't sell well initially, but became a coveted item after they removed it from the menu and brought it back only for limited periods and at selected locations.
- Exclusivity is about restricting access to people who meet certain criteria (e.g. wealth, prestige, knowledge, connections). Rue La La (a website for discounted designer items) became popular when it started to run flash sales for just 1-2 days each, generating perceived scarcity for its discounted products. In addition, you can only access the website through an invitation from an existing user, which creates an additional sense of exclusivity.



A note of caution: Social Currency is built on intrinsic motivation. When you pay someone to refer others, it may actually *reduce* the level of sharing to what's proportionate to the amount of financial incentive.



Principle #2: Triggers



A trigger is something that reminds you of something else. For example, the smell of food reminds you that it's time for lunch, or the word "dog" reminds you of the word "cat".

- People don't always share what's the most interesting, novel or surprising. Instead, people tend to talk about whatever's at the top of their minds, especially during casual chats. If your product/idea is linked to a trigger that people encounter frequently, then they're more likely to talk about it. Researchers found that playing French music at a restaurant triggered more purchases of French wine, whereas playing German music triggered more purchases German wine. In 1997, Mars chocolate

KEY QUOTES

"The mere fact that something isn't readily available can make people value it more and tell others to capitalize on the social currency of knowing about it or having it."

"Top of mind leads to tip of tongue."

"People often talk about whatever comes to mind, so the more often people think about a product or idea, the more it will be talked about."

bars saw a jump in sales due to extensive media coverage about NASA's mission to planet Mars.

- There's also a difference between immediate vs ongoing WOM. Things that are novel or interesting (e.g. a colleague coming to work in a jewel-studded suit) may trigger immediate WOM, but the novelty soon fizzles out. To keep people talking weeks and months later, you need to design products/messages that are linked to cues in the environment.
- Generally, an interesting/clever slogan is less effective in changing behavior than one with a strong trigger. In a study, students were asked to provide feedback on 2 public-health slogans: "Live the healthy way, eat five fruits and veggies a day" and "Each and every dining-hall tray needs five fruits and veggies a day." The students preferred the 1st slogan to the 2nd one. Yet, the latter was more effective in shaping behaviors—students who saw the 2nd slogan and used trays in the cafeterias ended up eating 25% more fruits and vegetables.



An effective trigger should fulfil 3 criteria:

- Frequency: Choose a stimulus that people will encounter regularly in their daily lives. For example, Budweiser ran a campaign that showed people greeting each other with "Wassup?" while drinking Budweiser. This was silly but nonetheless effective since "Wassup" was frequently used by young men at that time, making it an effective trigger or reminder to drink Budweiser.
- Relevance: There should be a strong and relatively unique link between the product/idea and the stimulus. For example, the color red is a weak trigger as it's associated with many things from Coke to love and danger. Kit Kat's jingle in the 1980s ("Have a break, Have a Kit Kat") was wildly successful. Then in 2007, it successfully revived the brand by repeatedly pairing itself with coffee. Coffee is great trigger for Kit Kat because (i) "Kit Kat and coffee" sounds good, (ii) it builds on the notion of having Kit Kat during a break (or coffee break), and (iii) coffee is a frequent stimulus.
- Context: Choose triggers that can be found near the desired behavior, so they can trigger action before they're

KEY QUOTES

"Social currency gets people talking, but triggers keep them talking."

"Accessible thoughts and ideas lead to action."

"The more things a given cue is associated with, the weaker any given association."

"By acting as reminders, triggers not only get people talking, they keep them talking."

forgotten. For example, if you want people to use reusable grocery bags, consider using a shopping list as a trigger (so they'll remember to bring the bags *before they* leave home). Likewise, there's no point using camels as a trigger if you're targeting people in New York City—since they rarely encounter a camel, they won't think about your product/message.



You can even use your competitors as a trigger by using the “poison parasite” approach. Design your marketing campaign to establish a link with your competitor's product or message, e.g. create a spoof of their ad. That way, each time someone sees your competitor's ad, they'll think of you.



Principle #3: Emotion



Emotions can make us laugh, shout, talk, share, and buy things. The question is, what type of messages/ideas will trigger emotions that lead to action?

- Berger found that **both positive and negative emotions can spur action. What's more important is the level of arousal triggered by the emotions.** When we're aroused, our hearts beat faster, our blood pressure increases, and we're ready for action. High-arousal emotions prepare us for action and *increase* the likelihood of us talking about or sharing something. Low-arousal emotions lull us into a state of inaction to *decrease* the likelihood of sharing.
- High-arousal emotions include positive emotions (e.g. awe, excitement, amusement) and negative ones (e.g. anger and anxiety).

Emotion	You're more likely to share when...
Awe (+)	You're inspired by a story of a nerdy guy who won a talent show with his amazing voice
Excitement (+)	You've just returned from an amazing holiday with lots of pictures
Amusement (+)	You can't stop laughing at a funny video of a baby
Anger (-)	You're furious about news of a tax increase
Anxiety (-)	You're anxious about news of a new life-threatening virus

- Low-arousal emotions can also be positive or negative:

KEY QUOTES

“When we care, we share.”

“We need to pick the right emotions to evoke. We need to kindle the fire.”

Emotion	You're less likely to share when...
Contentment (+)	You're feel relaxed after a good massage
Sadness (-)	You're saddened by news of someone's death



To get people to share, focus on kindling high-arousal emotions.

- Don't just focus on facts and information in your marketing messages. Figure out how you can make them care. You can find emotional hooks in any product, service or message. For example, Google's 2008 "Parisian Love" campaign told a love story using a series of Google searches—studying abroad, cafes in Paris, how to impress a French girl, churches in Paris, how to assemble a baby crib, etc. In *Made to Stick*, Chip and Dan Heath suggest using the "Three Whys" to find an idea's emotional core—ask yourself why something is important, and keep drilling down by asking "Why" at least 3x.
- You can also create emotional arousal using situational factors, or targeting people who're already fired up. For example, people are more likely to share something (or respond to an ad) when they're in a state of arousal, e.g. just after exercise, at the height of a crime drama, or just after watching an exciting game show.



Principle #4: Public



When something is public and observable, we're more likely to discuss and imitate it, making it more likely to spread. Conversely, it's hard to mimic or talk about things we don't see.

- We tend to follow others on the assumption that if lots of people are doing something, it must be right or good. Psychologists call this Social Proof or herd mentality. Social Proof influences everything we do, from what we buy/eat, to what career we choose and whether we pay our taxes. We'd choose a crowded restaurant over an empty one, and add money to an already-full tip jar instead of an empty one. In fact, 1 in 10 kidney patients refuse a kidney donation even though it would've been a match—they wrongly assume that if others have rejected the kidney before them, it must be a lousy kidney!

KEY QUOTES

"Rather than harping on features or facts, we need to focus on feelings; the underlying emotions that motivate people to action."

"Any sort of arousal, whether from emotional or physical sources, and even arousal due to the situation itself...can boost transmission."

"Making something more observable makes it easier to imitate."

"We assume that if other people are doing something, it must be a good idea."

"Behavior is public and thoughts are private."

- Public choices and behaviors are more likely to be imitated than private ones. Items like shirts and cars are more likely to spread as a fashion statement or status symbol because they're *highly visible*. On the other hand, we don't notice the socks or toothpaste used by others, making them less likely to spread via WOM. Even if everyone in a room is feeling uncomfortable about a task, they'll still carry on if others *appear* to be ok with it—we can only imitate public behavior, not private thoughts.



To make your product/idea spread, you need to make the private public. Create Social Proof by making hidden choices and behaviors visible in 2 ways:

- Self-advertising: Design products, campaigns or behaviors that are so visible that they advertise themselves, e.g. Apple's prominent logo on its computers, Pringles' unique tubes for its potato chips, or other distinctive shapes, sounds and features. Members of the Movember Foundation managed to raise awareness of prostate cancer (a serious but seldom-discussed problem in men's health) by growing their moustaches every November—in so doing, they became walking advertisements for their cause.
- Behavioral residue: Create physical traces that will remain even *after* an action or behavior is completed, e.g. giving people "I voted" stickers when they vote. Lululemon makes high-quality shopping bags that people keep for daily use, thus generating both Social Currency and Social Proof.



On the other hand, if you're trying to discourage undesirable behaviors (e.g. drink-driving, theft or drugs), you should *avoid* focusing on the problem.

- For sample, the "Just Say No" anti-drug campaign ended up *increasing* drug use because (i) it increased the visibility of drug-use, and (ii) it created the impression that many young, cool people were using drugs.
- A more effective approach would be to (i) hide the undesired behavior (i.e. make it private or unseen), and (ii) promote the desired behavior instead. Instead of highlighting the problem of stealing wood from a national park, promote how you can preserve the forest by not removing the wood.

KEY QUOTES

"The more public a product or service is, the more it triggers people to take action."

"If something is built to show, it's built to grow."

"If you want to get people not to do something, don't tell them that lots of their peers are doing it."



Principle #5: Practical Value

⚡ People like to help others. We'll naturally pass on content that has practical value, e.g. things that can help others to save time or money, improve their health, etc. While Social Currency is about making ourselves look good, Practical Value is driven by altruism and our desire to help the recipients.

- To increase the likelihood of your content being shared, you need to make it stand out by (i) highlighting the incredible value being offered (monetary or otherwise) and (ii) packaging it in a way that can be easily passed on.

💰 Highlighting incredible value:

- People assess value using reference points rather than the absolute value of a product/service. A \$1 coffee may seem cheap in New York but exorbitant in rural India. A \$50 dress will sell better just by having a "Sale" sign with an original price of \$100 (making \$100 the reference point).
- Generally, saving 50% sounds more exciting than saving 10%. However, diminishing sensitivity says that a change will have a smaller impact as it moves farther from the reference point. For example, buying a \$20 item at \$10 sounds like a great deal, but buying a \$1,000 item at \$990 doesn't. That's because \$10 is much further from \$1,000 than it is to \$20.
- To frame your offers optimally, use the rule of 100:
 - (i) If an item costs less than \$100, frame the price reduction in *percentage terms* to make it appear more significant (e.g. 20% off a \$50 item sounds better than saving \$10).
 - (ii) If an item costs more than \$100, frame the price reduction in *absolute or dollar terms* to make it sound more attractive (e.g. saving \$200 sounds better than 20% off a \$1000 item).
- An offer is also more likely to be shared if it's (i) surprising or surpasses expectations, and (ii) limited in availability

KEY QUOTES

"Practical advice is shareable advice."

"If Social Currency is about information senders and how sharing makes them look, Practical Value is mostly about the information receiver."

(e.g. restricted to X items per customer or for a limited time).

- You can also make the value more obvious or visible to create Social Proof, e.g. having a digital sign at the checkout counter to show how much other customers have saved, or ringing a bell each time someone enjoys a deal.



Packaging your content. Information can also have high practical value. To make your content more shareable:

- Keep it short, e.g. having a 1 page email with 3-4 main points about 1 main topic, with links for people to click on if they wish to find out more.
- Keep it targeted. Broad content or stories may be relevant to a wider audience, but narrower/targeted content can be more compelling. When something reminds you specifically of someone, you're more likely to pass it along.



Principle #6: Stories



Stories are powerful information vessels. They capture our attention, spark our imagination, tug at our heartstrings, and convey underlying messages in a way that can change our attitudes and behaviors.

- Stories provide a fast and easy way for people to pass on lots of information in a vivid, engaging way. Consider how fables, fairy tales and famous works (e.g. Shakespeare) have been used over the generations to impart morals and complex lessons/themes.
- Stories can also be more persuasive than factual articles or advertisements as people become emotionally engaged and are less likely to challenge the facts.



To spread an idea, you need to wrap it in a broader narrative, i.e. to embed your product/idea in a captivating story that people want to pass on.

- For example, if you receive exceptional customer service, you may feel compelled to share the experience with

KEY QUOTES

"The fact that a deal won't be around forever makes people feel that it must be a really good one."

"While broadly relevant content could be shared more, content that is obviously relevant to a narrow audience may actually be more viral."

"People don't just share information, they tell stories."

"Stories carry things. A lesson or moral. Information or a take-home message."

"While people focus on the story itself, information comes along for the ride."

your friends. In the process, you'll also share about the company, the product/service, how they solved your problems and exceeded your expectations.

- Stories also tend to spread via WOM because they create Social Currency by making people look cool or informed, trigger high-arousal Emotions, and provide Practical Value in the form of useful information or advice. For instance, people were intrigued by the story of how Jared Fogle supposedly lost 245 pounds eating Subway sandwiches. They wanted to know how he could lose so much weight eating fast food. In the process, they learned about Subway's healthy and tasty food options.



However, it's not enough to simply weave your brand into a story. You must ensure that the virality is valuable, i.e. **your brand or core product benefit must be so essential to the story that people can't retell the story without mentioning it.** This is crucial since people tend to drop the irrelevant details as they pass on the stories. The only way to connect the word-of-mouth back to you is to ensure the information you want people to notice/remember is integral to the story itself.

- In 2004, Ron Bensimhon crashed the Olympics in a publicity stunt, diving into an Olympics pool in Polka dot tights and tutus. Although the stunt was widely shared and discussed, no one spoke of the online casino GoldenPalace.com which was written in bold across Ron's chest. There was simply no relevant link between the stunt and the casino.
- On the other hand, Dove's 2006 "Evolution" video revealed the amount of makeup and photo-editing used to create the stunning-looking women that we see in advertisements. The video was viewed 1.7 mil times within a month of its upload on Youtube, and 12 mil times within the first year. It brought millions of dollars worth of exposure for Dove, stimulated discussion on the definition of beauty, reminded people that what we see in ads are unreal, and tied in neatly with Dove's campaign for "real beauty" to celebrate diverse and natural beauty in women.

KEY QUOTES

"That is the magic of stories. Information travels under the guise of what seems like idle chatter."

"We need to make our message so integral to the narrative that people can't tell the story without it."